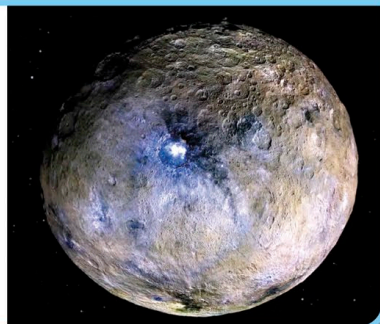


Scientists
landed a
spacecraft on
an asteroid for
the first time
in 2001.

LARGEST ASTEROID

One asteroid, Ceres, is so much bigger than any other asteroid that some astronomers now call it a "dwarf planet". Its icy surface is heavily pitted by impacts, with a strange pyramid-shaped mountain 5 km (3 miles) high. Small white spots on Ceres might be patches of salt from an underground ocean.



Asteroids are heavily cratered because of collisions

Some asteroids may be rich in valuable metals such as platinum